

SOMEWHERE OVER THE RAINBOW

By Jim Bishop

Nearly everyone looks back at their senior year in high school as one of the best times of their life. Mine was no exception. The knowledge that this was the last year that I really HAD TO go to school gave me a smug feeling. Anticipating such exciting events as our senior picnic, the senior prom and the other activities associated with the final year in high school kept me in an excellent frame of mind all year long. After graduation, I had a good summer job working for a local contractor, building homes, and was going to the University of Oklahoma in the fall. That summer of passage was a continuation of the good times I had enjoyed as a senior in high school. That was the summer when the Order of Rainbow had their state convention in our town.

We had been hearing about the convention from the local Rainbow girls for weeks and were aware that there would be hundreds of pretty girls in our midst for several days. There was to be a big dance on the last night of the convention, which meant all eligible young men in town were going to be asked to serve as dates for many of the girls. The local members of the order had arranged for thier dates well in

advance, knowing that the competition would be keen as soon as the out of town girls began to arrive.

We had two local hotels, the Jens Marie and the Arcade, which were preparing to house as many of the girls as possible. However, they didn't have sufficient capacity to take them all, so arrangements were made for many of the girls to stay in private homes. The meetings for the convention would be held in the Masonic Lodge Hall, which was upstairs in one of the downtown buildings. The convention was held on a weekend, and by the time all those cute girls started to making their presence known in our town, all of the young men were in an absolute state of shock. Never had so many pretty Oklahoma girls assembled in one place at one time..at least not in our lifetimes.

The girls came in all shapes and sizes. Tall, short, plump, willowy, blonde, brunette, redhead, plain, pretty, cute, beautiful. You name it. They had it. They were all wearing pretty colored, summery dresses, each of which sported a round badge, festooned with a strand of colorful ribbons which hung down almost to the waist. These badges had their names and hometowns printed on them. There were names like Bobbie Sue, and Jerry, and Nancy Lee, and Rosemary, and Mary Frances. They came from Stroud and Chicasha, and Stillwater and Tulsa, and Muskogee, and Oklahoma City and dozens of other towns throughout the state.

It was "too much".

The first day of the convention, several of my friends and I just happened to be standing on the sidewalk in front of the Masonic Building waiting for the girls to be dismissed for the day. We tried to look nonchalant as they came down the stairs and poured out onto the sidewalk, laughing and babbling as teenage girls always do when they are in large groups. As the crowd began to build up on the sidewalk, we were gradually pushed, at first to the edge, then finally surrounded by the waves of girls. Some of the local girls waved and spoke to us, bringing others over and introducing them to the boys. The hunt for dates to the dance had begun.

While I was standing there, enjoying the ~~sites~~ ^{excitement}, I saw this beautiful girl working her way through the crowd toward me. She had coal black hair, cat-green eyes, and a dark sun tan. She was smiling big with a mouth full of even white teeth that looked like they could ^{snap a} ~~bite~~ ten penny nail. ~~sun tan~~ I turned to look for whoever she might be trying to get to in the crush of the crowd, then turned back toward her. She was standing in front of me with her hand outstretched saying,

"Hi. I'm Jayne Chilton."

Jayne Chilton was wearing a powder blue dress which was stretched out over one of the prettiest shapes I had ever seen on a girl. Her hand was still extended, waiting for me to take it.

"I'm Jayne Chilton." she repeated over the noise around us.

I looked at her name tag and that's exactly what it said.

"You sure are." was all I could manage to mutter. I mean, just how sharp can you expect to be when some dreamboat of a girl that you would trade your eye teeth for walks up to you and introduces herself like that?

I stood there, trying to figure what I could say next. First thing to do, stupid boy is to grab hold of that delicate hand she's holding out to you. I took her hand in mine and she had a firm grip, stronger than I would expect for a girl. Her hand was cool and smooth. I knew she must be able to feel the pumping of my pulse. While I was trying to think of something clever to say, she leaned toward me and said,

"Would you be my escort for the dance tomorrow night?"

She might just as well have asked me, how I'd like to have a new Ford convertible to take to college. I finally recovered my cool enough to ask her if she would like to go across the street to the Rexall Drug Store where we could sit in a booth and discuss our future over a couple of cokes.

"Sure. Why not?" she agreed.

A crowd of us went to the drug store, filling all the tables and booths with our youthful chatter. She proceeded to kid me about the look I had on my face when she walked up to me. When I asked her why she had picked me, she told me that one of the local girls had pointed me out to her and said I was a

"real neat guy". She also knew I didn't have a date for the dance because the girl I was dating at the time was on vacation with her parents.

Jayne and I hit it off big. She liked to talk, I liked to listen. We both liked a lot of the same things, tennis, swimming, greasy hamburgers, and Artie Shaw's music. She was part indian, which accounted for her dark beauty, and she had a very adventurous spirit, not fearing any thing or anybody, a fact I was to learn later. She was from Oklahoma City, had one younger sister and a little brother. Her father had died two years ago, a fact she was still trying to get over, and her mother worked in one of the department stores. She planned to go to Stevens college in the fall and then to the University of Missouri where she would take a degree in Journalism. She wanted to be a writer, maybe even a war correspondent.

There was some type of assembly that night , but we agreed on a date afterwards. I managed to talk my Dad into letting me borrow the family car for the evening and picked Jayne up at nine o'clock, after the meeting. She had to be in by ten o'clock, so we didn't have much time. We went to Pat's English Inn for a hamburger and a coke, then headed for the hotel. She was staying at the Jens Marie. All the parking spaces near the hotel were taken. There were even some cars unloading late arrivals, so we had to park in the next

block. We had fifteen minutes when we pulled into the parking space. I started to open my door and get out of the car.

"What's your hurry?" Jayne wanted to know.

"I thought you had to be back by ten o'clock."

"I do, but we've got some time." As she said that, she moved across the seat of the car toward me. She pushed her lovely sun tanned boby against mine and we got friendly. My oh my, that girl sure knew how to kiss.

Our fifteen minutes vanished rapidly. Like they say, Time flies when you're having fun. She opened her door, grabbed my hand and pulled me across the seat behind her. She hit the sidewalk running and laughing. "C'mon. I'll race you." She took off in a dead run for the hotel entrance in the next block. She was wiping at her mouth with a handkerchief and looking back over her shoulder at me as she ran she shouted,

"Wipe the lipstick off your face. You look like a mess." She beat me by about two lengths and wasn't even breathing hard when I caught up to her, after she had pushed through the big revolving doors into the lobby. She laughed as she saw me puffing in behind her.

The lobby was crowded with Rainbow Girls, and chaperones, and Eastern Star ladies, and parents, and a number of local boys who, like myself were bringing their dates back before the curfew. Jayne reached out and took my hand. She squeezed it hard and told me, "I've had a super time tonight. I can't

wait for the dance tomorrow night."

"Neither can I." I had never meant anything anymore in my life. This was some girl.

"Do you want to double date?" I asked her.

"If it's alright with you, I'd rather not." was her answer. "We can have more fun if we go by ourselves, I promise." She squeezed my hand again when she said that.

She kept her promise.

The dance was held at the country club, a big sprawling spanish style building which was located about eight miles east of town, out near the lake. It was crowded with girls in frilly, summery formal gowns, and boys in suits and ties, much more uncomfortable than they would like to admit. There were chaperones all over the place, just daring any one to get out of hand. They would frown at you if you looked like you wanted to go outside with your girl. It was permitted to go out onto the back portico which extended along the rear of the ballroom to get a breath of fresh air after a set of dances. Jayne and I went out onto the portico , locked arm in arm after she complained of being too hot and tired to keep dancing. She had been given the big rush by the stags and had danced every dance. Her beauty, and personality attracted the boys in large numbers and I was having a difficult time even finishing a complete dance with her.

There were a number of other couples enjoying the summer breeze which was coming in from across the lake. Quiet conversations and occasional laughter punctuated the warmth of the night. We walked over to the railing at the edge of the portico, holding hands. She was gripping mine with that strong enjoyable touch. Jayne, looking out across the patterns of light and shadow that were cast on the grass and shrubbery below the railing, asked. "What's out there?"

"The golf course." I answered

"Is it very far?"

"Just down the hill about a hundred yards or so."

The band had started to play again and everyone began to walk back into the ballroom.

"Wait a minute." she whispered to me. I had started to get off of the railing where I was sitting, assuming we would go back in with the others.

Jayne was bent over, unbuckling the straps on her shoes. When she had taken them both off, she held them in one hand, hiked up the skirt of her evening gown to about knee level, then crawled over the railing and dropped to the grass below.

She looked up at me, green eyes flashing a challenge,

"C'mon." she said and turned and began running down the hill toward the golf course. I followed, but still with my shoes on, wondering what kind of craziness she was going to come up with next. She had a good start on me, but I could see her in the distance as she ran. She had her gown gathered up in her arms around her hips, long tan legs running up the

freshly cut grass fairway. I could hear her laughter, drifting back to me through the warm summer night. The music from the ballroom, grew fainter as the distance increased between us and the country club. She dissapeared from my view as she turned past a bend in the fairway. She was about two hundred feet ahead of me. That indian girl could run! When I reached the bend in the fairway, I could see her standing in the middle of the golf green, which was raised like a round platform, bordered on one side by a sand trap, and on the other by a small pond. She was pulling at her evening gown, trying to straighten it, I assumed. By the time I reached the green, her gown was lying on the grass. She stood there in a bra and half slip. holding onto the pole in the cup for support. She was gulping for air, trying to get her wind and laughing at the astonished look I had on my face.

My own shortness of breath was aggravated by the sight of her standing there in the dark, tan skin contrasted against her white underthings. I flopped down on the grass at her feet, chest pumping for air, breathing hard, and dizzy with excitement. Jayne lowered herself to the grass beside me and lay across my chest. We coordinated our breathing and lay there for a long time, not saying anything, just feeling our hearts pounding almost in exact cadence. Finally, she broke the silence.

"You know, my Daddy always told me not to get involved in any 'funny business' with boys. I always told him I didn't.

But I dont consider this to be 'funny business'. As far as I'm concerned, this is real serious business."

She then proceeded to show me just how serious she was.

Jayne and I saw one another several more times that summer. I would drive down to Oklahoma City and we would have dates. We went to hear Artie Shaw when his band came to Springlake Casino. She wrote me gushy letters that would curl my toes. I would write her back, trying to sound romantic and witty like her letters but never, I'm afraid. succeeding. She did go to Stevens in the fall, just like she said she was going to. Our letters continued, but on a less frequent basis. Eventually we stopped writing altogether and I never saw or heard from her again. Someone that knew her from their Classen High days together told me that she had married a Navy pilot and had moved to Pensacola, Florida. I hoped he had an adventurous nature.

Whenever I have heard the song, "Over The Rainbow" from then on, who do you think comes to my mind?

end.